important that the boss had been so cool and reassuring at half-time, just when you'd have expected him, or any other manager, to be blowing his top. He's a very demanding man but, in all my time as a United player, the manager was the one person who always seemed to have even more faith in us than we had in ourselves.

As I've said, the boss made players feel special: when he told you he was pleased with something you did, in a match or in training, that counted for something. I'm not sure what the manager thought about me getting the England captain's job. He didn't say anything to me about it at the time, although I remember reading quotes from him in the papers. He said he didn't really see me as a captain and wasn't sure that it was a very good idea. But during the qualifying campaign for the World Cup, after we'd beaten Germany, he actually made a point of saying to me:

'You've surprised me. This has made you a better player. Maybe a better person. I'd never thought you could be a captain.'

To hear that from the manager meant a lot to me, like when I was a boy and Dad had told me he was pleased about something I'd done. It was always the manager's way of handling players, keeping them focused: to lift them up when that was what they needed and then knock them down if he thought they were getting above themselves. When I first got into United's first team as a regular, my squad number was 24. The following season I was given the number 10 shirt. That meant a great deal to me: Denis Law and Mark Hughes had both worn it before me. Maybe the history that went with the number was why I scored so many goals wearing it. I remember, though, the summer we signed Teddy Sheringham, the boss actually took the trouble to phone me when I was away on vacation in Malta to tell me he was taking that squad number off me. No explanation, no alternative and no argument. I remember saying to Gary Neville at the time:

'What's he done that for? Why would he phone to tell me that? Did he just want to make sure he ruined my vacation?'

I was devastated, trying to workout what I'd done wrong. Then, a month later when we turned up for pre-season training, he had a new shirt ready: the number 7. The boss handed me Eric Cantona's squad number. The surprise of that honor stopped me in my tracks.

As well as preparing teams for games, the manager was always very careful to prepare each individual too. In the dressing room, whether it was before a Champions League match or before a pre-season friendly, he made